LISTEN · LEARN · SPEAK

Why Being Bored Is Good for You

The experiment where people chose an electric shock, why a boring job can make you more creative, colourful English for boring moments – and Jack, a stuck train and a very patient cow.



Name: _____

Date: _____

My score: _____ / 100 ⭐

★ How to use this worksheet

1 · Before you listen 🧠
Do the warm-up and learn the key words. Questions with 🧠 can be answered before listening.

2 · While you listen 🎧
Answer the 🎧 questions. The ⏱️ times show where to find each part of the video.

3 · After you listen 💬
Solve the crossword, try five bored minutes a day – and tell us your most boring moment!

0 Warm-up: My boredom check

fun · no points

Be honest! Tick everything that is true for you. 😄

- ☐ 📱 I check my phone in queues
- ☐ 🍫 I eat snacks when I'm bored
- ☐ 🚶 I walk without headphones
- ☐ ☕ ...and while the kettle boils
- ☐ 🛏️ I check my phone in bed
- ☐ 💡 I get ideas in the shower

My boredom score: _____ / 6

Guess! People sat alone for 15 minutes. They could press a button for a small electric shock. How many men pressed it?

(a) nobody (b) about two out of three (c) every single one

🎧 **Check your guess at ⏱️ 2:41**

Jack: "I read the safety sign about eleven times!" 🚆



💬 Let's talk

Say your answers out loud – or write them in your notebook.

1. When do you usually feel bored?

2. What's the first thing you do when you're bored?

3. Where do your best ideas usually come to you?

4. What's the most boring thing you've ever had to do?

1 Key words

vocabulary · 10 points

Match each word or phrase (1–10) to its meaning (a–j). Write the letter in the box. 🧠 Then check at ⏱️ 13:23 and ⏱️ 14:22

- ☐ **1.** to daydream
- ☐ **2.** to let your mind wander
- ☐ **3.** an urge
- ☐ **4.** to resist the urge
- ☐ **5.** restless
- ☐ **6.** a distraction
- ☐ **7.** to kill time
- ☐ **8.** scrolling
- ☐ **9.** a power cut
- ☐ **10.** a participant

a) a strong, sudden feeling that you want to do something
b) something that takes your attention away from what you're doing
c) to think about pleasant or random things while you're awake
d) moving through things on your phone with your finger, often without thinking
e) a person who takes part in a study
f) to not do something, although you really want to
g) when the electricity suddenly stops
h) when your thoughts move from one thing to another, with no plan
i) to do something unimportant while you're waiting
j) unable to relax or stay still



Pronunciation corner 🔊 **DAY**-dream · **REST**-less · dis-**TRAC**-tion · par-**TI**-ci-pant · urge (/ɜːdʒ/). Fun fact: **bored** sounds exactly like **board** (/bɔːd/)! Say it: *"I'm bored, not boring!"*

2 First listen: the big idea

listening · 2 points

Watch the whole episode once without stopping. Which sentence is the **main message**? 🎧

- (a) Boredom can be useful: when your mind wanders, it makes new connections – so give yourself a few quiet minutes without your phone.
- (b) Boredom is always bad for you, so you should keep busy every minute of the day.
- (c) The best way to stop feeling bored is to use your phone more often.



Jack's tip: First listen = the **big picture**. Don't stop the video and don't worry about every word. Second listen = the **details**. That's when you answer the 🎧 questions.

🔮 **Predict before you listen!** (no points) Seven of these words are in the episode. One is **not**. Circle the one you think you **won't** hear – then check while you listen.

cow · **kettle** · **plastic cups** · **dentist** · **bakery** · **robot** · **bicycle** · **umbrella**

3 Know it or hear it? quiz + listening 10 points

Circle a, b or c. Questions 🧠 1–5: you can probably answer them **before** you listen. Questions 🎧 6–10: listen to find the answer.



🧠 YOU MIGHT ALREADY KNOW

1. "The film was really slow. I was _____."

(a) bored
(b) boring
(c) bore

🧠 Tricky – think about it!

2. "To kill time" means…

(a) to work really fast
(b) to waste money
(c) to do something while you wait

🧠 Look at Exercise 1

3. "I _____ nothing all weekend."

(a) made
(b) did
(c) passed

🧠 Grammar you know

4. "It was like watching paint dry." It was…

(a) very exciting
(b) very messy
(c) very boring

🧠 Imagine it!

5. "Restless" means…

(a) unable to relax or stay still
(b) very sleepy
(c) without a day off

🧠 Look at Exercise 1

🎉 **How many did you know?**
Now press play and test your ears!

🎧 LISTEN AND FIND OUT

6. How much battery did Jack's phone have on the train?

(a) thirty percent
(b) three percent
(c) thirteen percent

🎧 ⏱️ 0:05

7. When people did the thinking task at home, how many cheated?

(a) about a third
(b) almost nobody
(c) everyone

🎧 ⏱️ 2:41

8. For the boring job, people had to _____ numbers from an old phone book.

(a) call
(b) copy
(c) sell

🎧 ⏱️ 5:25

9. On her boring walk, where did Lucy solve a work problem?

(a) at the bus stop
(b) in the shower
(c) near the bakery

🎧 ⏱️ 8:40

10. What did Jack's nephew play with for three hours?

(a) an expensive robot
(b) the box
(c) a notebook

🎧 ⏱️ 8:40

🍽️ **Fun fact:** Lucy's secret thinking time? Washing the dishes! Jack's best ideas come in the shower. 🚿

4 True or false? listening 6 points

Listen and circle **T** (true) or **F** (false). The ⏱️ times help you find the answer.

1	Jack's train journey normally takes about one hour.	T	F	⏱️ 0:05
2	The cow looked away first.	T	F	⏱️ 0:05
3	In Wilson's studies, most people enjoyed sitting alone with their thoughts.	T	F	⏱️ 2:41
4	One man pressed the shock button 190 times.	T	F	⏱️ 2:41
5	The people who only *read* the phone numbers were the most creative.	T	F	⏱️ 5:25
6	The study proves that being bored will turn you into a genius.	T	F	⏱️ 5:25

5 Two studies and a train 🔍 listening 6 points



Who or what is each sentence about? Write **A**, **B** or **C**. ⏱️ 0:05 · 2:41 · 5:25

A · "Just think" ⚡
2014 · Timothy Wilson, University of Virginia

B · Bored and creative? 🥤
Sandi Mann & Rebekah Cadman, Univ. of Central Lancashire

C · Jack's train 🐄
a field, a cow and a dead phone

1	People copied numbers from an old telephone book.	☐
2	People sat alone in a plain, empty room for six to fifteen minutes.	☐
3	He read the safety sign on the window about eleven times.	☐
4	Some people gave themselves a small electric shock.	☐
5	After about an hour, his mind went quiet – and he had an idea.	☐
6	People thought of different uses for two plastic cups.	☐

6 Bored or boring? new! -ed or -ing 6 points



Tick the right word. ⏱️ 17:39

😩 **-ED = how you feel.** *I'm bored. I'm interested.*

📺 **-ING = what makes you feel it.** *The film is boring.*

1. The film was so _____ that I fell asleep. 😴
☐ 😩 bored ☐ 📺 boring

2. I'm _____ – let's go for a walk! 🚶
☐ 😩 bored ☐ 📺 boring

3. Lucy was very _____ in Jack's cow story. 🐄
☐ 😩 interested ☐ 📺 interesting

4. Jack's train story was really _____. 🚆
☐ 😩 interested ☐ 📺 interesting

5. I was _____ that so many men pressed it. ⚡
☐ 😩 surprised ☐ 📺 surprising

6. Copying phone numbers is very _____. 📖
☐ 😩 tired ☐ 📺 tiring

7 "That's the power gone!" listening 10 points



Two flatmates on a Sunday evening – and the electricity has just gone off. Listen at ⏱️ 12:22 and write **one word** in each gap (1–8). Then answer A and B. The breakdown at ⏱️ 13:23 can help.

JACK
Well, that's the 1 _____ gone. The whole street is dark.





LUCY
You're joking. And my phone's almost dead. What are we 2 _____ to do now?

JACK
I don't know. We could just sit here and talk, like people did in the old days.





LUCY
I'm already bored 3 _____, and it's only been five minutes.

JACK
Come on, it's not that 4 _____. Let's play a game. I'll think of a word, and you guess it. You can ask me twenty 5 _____.





LUCY
Fine. Is it something you can 6 _____?

JACK
No.





LUCY
Is it bigger than a car?

JACK
Much bigger.





LUCY
Is it a train stuck in a field?

JACK
Very funny. No.





LUCY
Okay, I'm actually starting to enjoy this. I can't believe I'm saying that.

JACK
See? Being bored isn't the 7 _____ of the world.





LUCY
Let's not get 8 _____ away. But I'll admit, this is better than scrolling.

A. Or say: "There's a power _____."

B. The game is better than _____.

🎭 **Say it out loud!** Play both parts – then play "twenty questions" in English with a friend, or in your head!

8 Phrases to steal

expressions · 4 points

Match each phrase from the chat (1–4) to its meaning (a–d). ⏱️ 13:23

- ☐ **1.** "What are we supposed to do now?"
- ☐ **2.** "It's not that bad."
- ☐ **3.** "It isn't the end of the world."
- ☐ **4.** "Let's not get carried away."

a) It's not a serious problem.
b) Let's not get too excited.
c) What should we do in this new situation?
d) You're exaggerating a little.

9 So boring!

idioms · 6 points



English has colourful ways to say something is boring! Complete each sentence with a word from the box. ⏱️ 14:22

dragged · **flew** · **paint** · **stiff** · **tears** · **thumbs**

1. 😭 The lecture was so long that it bored me to _____.
2. 🎨 Honestly, that football match was like watching _____ dry.
3. 👍 I sat in the waiting room twiddling my _____ for an hour.
4. 🐌 The last hour of work really _____.
5. ✈️ We were having so much fun – time just _____!
6. 🥶 Two hours with nothing to do? I was bored _____!



Jack's tip: "Stiff" means hard and difficult to move – so *bored stiff* is like your body is frozen by boredom! 🥶 And **time drags** 🐌 is the opposite of **time flies** ✈️.

10 What do you do with time?

new! collocations · 6 points



Complete with **spent**, **kill**, **waste**, **save**, **make** or **take**. ⏱️ 14:22 · 17:39

1. 🚆 I _____ two hours on the train.
2. 🎬 We had an hour to _____ before the film.
3. 📱 Don't _____ your evening scrolling!
4. 🛒 Shopping online can _____ you time.
5. 🫖 I always _____ time for my tea.
6. 🙂 No hurry – _____ your time!

⏳ Time flies or time drags?

your opinion · no points

How does time feel for **you** in each situation? Tick one – then say it: *"At a party, time flies!"*

1. 🎉 at a party	☐ ✈️ flies	☐ 🐌 drags
2. 🏦 in a long queue	☐ ✈️ flies	☐ 🐌 drags
3. 🎬 watching a great film	☐ ✈️ flies	☐ 🐌 drags
4. 🦷 at the dentist's	☐ ✈️ flies	☐ 🐌 drags
5. 🏖️ on holiday	☐ ✈️ flies	☐ 🐌 drags
6. ⏰ Friday's last work hour	☐ ✈️ flies	☐ 🐌 drags

11 Say it better

common mistakes · 10 points

These sentences sound unnatural. Write a more natural version (2 points each). ⏱️ 17:39

😐 1. "I am boring." (you want to say how you feel) 😊 _____

😐 2. "Time is not passing." 😊 _____

😐 3. "I make nothing all weekend." 😊 _____

😐 4. "I'm bored to wait." 😊 _____

😐 5. "My phone is distracting me always." 😊 _____



Lucy's tip: Words like **always**, **often** and **never** usually go **before** the main verb: *"My phone always distracts me."* And after **of**, use **-ing**: *"I'm tired of waiting."*

🌱 Bored in a good way?

think · no points



Does each habit help you use boredom well – or not? ⏱️ 5:25 · 8:40 · 19:33

1. 🚌 Leaving your phone in your pocket at the bus stop.

☐ ✓ HELPS ☐ × DOESN'T HELP

2. 🍫 Opening the fridge every twenty minutes, just to look.

☐ ✓ HELPS ☐ × DOESN'T HELP

3. 🚶 Going for a short walk without headphones.

☐ ✓ HELPS ☐ × DOESN'T HELP

4. 📱 Scrolling for an hour every time you're bored.

☐ ✓ HELPS ☐ × DOESN'T HELP

5. 📓 Keeping a little notebook for your ideas.

☐ ✓ HELPS ☐ × DOESN'T HELP

6. ⏱️ Waiting two minutes before you pick up your phone.

☐ ✓ HELPS ☐ × DOESN'T HELP



⏱️ Jack's two-minute rule

Feel the urge to grab your phone? Wait **two minutes**. Count your breaths, look out of the window – or describe what you see in English: *"There's a woman with a red umbrella. The bus is late again."* If the urge is still there, fine – now it's a **choice**, not an automatic movement.

Try it now! Describe one thing you can see: _____

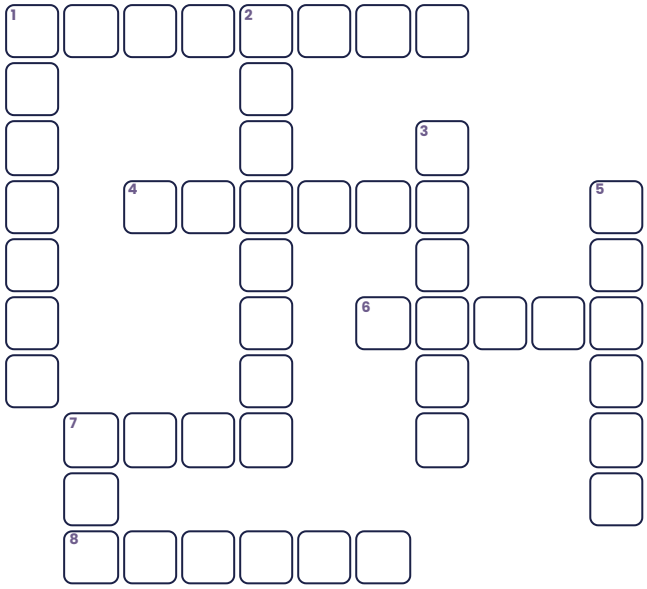


Did you know? 🧸 Sandi Mann looked at children on long flights. Children with a **whole bag of toys** picked up each thing and moved on quickly. Children with **one toy at a time** stayed busy for much longer – and a plain notebook and a pen kept them happy for ages! Just like Jack's nephew and the box. 📦 ⏱️ 8:40

12 Boredom crossword 🧩 puzzle 10 points



Read the clues and write the words in the grid (1 point each). The number in brackets is the number of letters. Letters that cross help you!



➡️ Across

1 To think about pleasant or random things while you're awake: to ___. (8)

4 Some people check their phones while they wait for the ___ to boil. (6)

6 Some people chose a small electric ___ instead of sitting quietly. (5)

7 Bored people thought of more uses for two plastic ___. (4)

8 Every morning, Jack makes tea and sits by the ___. (6)

⬇️ Down

1 Lucy was bored at the ___, waiting with her mouth open. (7)

2 Unable to relax or stay still – like Jack in his first half hour on the train. (8)

3 Jack's ___ played with the box, not the expensive robot. (6)

5 On her boring walk, Lucy solved a work problem near the ___. (6)

7 On the train, Jack had a staring contest with a ___ – and lost! (3)

13 The train, the cow and the idea 🐄 listening 6 points



Listen at ⏱️ 0:05 and ⏱️ 20:33. Put the events in the right order. Write 1–6 in the boxes.

☐ 🤫 After about an hour, his mind went quiet.

☐ 🔋 His phone was on three percent – soon it was dead.

☐ 🐄 He sat staring at a cow, and the cow stared back.

☐ 💡 Now he's calmer, with more ideas – even for the podcast!

☐ 🫖 He decided: the first twenty minutes of the day belong to him.

☐ 📱 He realised he always looked at his phone first thing in the morning.

Think about it 💭 (no points) Jack calls it "planned boredom". What would **your** first twenty minutes look like?

14 Your turn

writing · 8 points

2 points for each good sentence.



A. My most boring moment 🥱

Use one idiom from Exercise 9. *e.g. "Waiting six hours at the airport was like watching paint dry."*

B. Bored in a good way 🌱

Where will you be bored this week – and what will you do instead of your phone? *e.g. "At the bus stop, I'll look around."*

⏱️ My five bored minutes

your 7-day mission

Once a day, be bored for five minutes. No phone, no screen – just let your mind wander.



Day	Where	What I noticed – or my idea!	Done?
1	🚌 waiting for the bus		☐
2	☕ while the kettle boils		☐
3	🚶 a walk, no headphones		☐
4	🪟 tea by the window		☐
5	🛒 standing in a queue		☐
6	🗣️ describe it in English		☐
7	📓 write one bored idea		☐

✂️ Cut out and keep in your pocket

🥱 SO BORING!	⏳ TIME	🌱 GOOD BOREDOM	⚠️ -ED or -ING?
like watching paint dry	Time dragged.	Let your mind wander.	I'm bored. ✓
I'm bored stiff.	Time flew!	Resist the urge.	It's boring. ✓
It bored me to tears.	We had an hour to kill.	the two-minute rule	I'm boring. 😅

Can you do it now?

I can...	Not yet	Almost	Yes!
explain why boredom can sometimes help creativity.	😟	🙂	😄
say "I'm bored" (not "I'm boring") – and explain why.	😟	🙂	😄
use idioms like "bored stiff" and "like watching paint dry".	😟	🙂	😄
use spend, kill, waste and save with "time".	😟	🙂	😄



Share it with us! What's the most boring situation you've ever been in? Tell us in the comments with one of today's expressions: Was it **like watching paint dry**? Were you **bored stiff** – or **bored to tears**? 🐄

Answer key

Count your points and write your score on page 1!

0 · Warm-up & predict

Guess: b – 12 out of 18 men pressed it at least once (and 6 out of 24 women). · Predict: **bicycle** 🚲 isn't in the episode.

1 · Key words · 2 · The big idea

1 c · 2 h · 3 a · 4 f · 5 j · 6 b · 7 i · 8 d · 9 g · 10 e
Big idea: a (2 points)

3 · Know it or hear it?

1 a · 2 c · 3 b · 4 c · 5 a · 6 b · 7 a · 8 b · 9 c · 10 b

4 · True or false?

1 T · 2 F (Jack looked away first) · 3 F (most found it unpleasant) · 4 T · 5 T · 6 F (it was a small study – it doesn't prove that)

5 · Two studies and a train · 6 · Bored or boring?

5: 1 B · 2 A · 3 C · 4 A · 5 C · 6 B
6: 1 boring · 2 bored · 3 interested · 4 interesting · 5 surprised · 6 tiring

7 · "That's the power gone!"

1 power · 2 supposed · 3 stiff · 4 bad · 5 questions · 6 eat · 7 end · 8 carried · A cut · B scrolling

8 · Phrases to steal · 9 · So boring!

8: 1 c · 2 d · 3 a · 4 b
9: 1 tears · 2 paint · 3 thumbs · 4 dragged · 5 flew · 6 stiff

10 · What do you do with time?

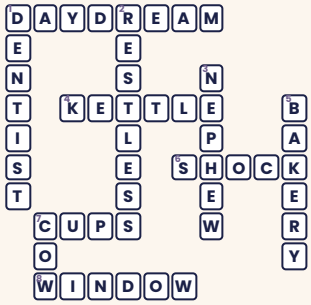
1 spent · 2 kill · 3 waste · 4 save · 5 make · 6 take

11 · Say it better (2 points each)

1 I'm bored. · 2 Time is going so slowly. / The day is really dragging. · 3 I did nothing all weekend. · 4 I'm bored of waiting. / I'm tired of waiting. · 5 My phone always distracts me. / I'm always getting distracted by my phone.
Bored in a good way? helps: 1, 3, 5, 6 · doesn't help: 2, 4

12 · Crossword

Across: 1 daydream · 4 kettle · 6 shock · 7 cups · 8 window
Down: 1 dentist · 2 restless · 3 nephew · 5 bakery · 7 cow



13 · The train story · 14 · Your turn

1 🔋 three percent · 2 🐄 the cow · 3 🤫 mind went quiet · 4 📱 phone first thing · 5 🫖 twenty minutes · 6 💡 calmer, more ideas
14: your own answers – 2 points per good sentence.

Your score

90–100 🏆 **Time flew!** · 70–89 ✨ **Not bored at all** · 50–69 🫖 **Planned boredom** · 0–49 🐄 **Stuck on the train – listen again!**

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